Incarnate

Notes of hazelnut and blueberry line the bottom of a cup, water drips down the corner of a mouth when sips are taken and it's swished around in inflated cheeks to wash out the taste of nuts and oil. Outside, obscurity.

Words sometimes flash on sterile screens to get a reading of cognitive activity—but what is it we gain from that?

Things that make impressions: it's sometimes related to the "blank slate", a metaphor for how the brain is impressed. It's dark. It's cold. There's virtually no gravity, the bones of the earth that hold everything to it. There are speckles, there are echoes. Even this, in itself, makes an impression.

The echo of annihilation, transformation, experience,

& what we take for granted.

A shadowy memory:

I was 9 years old, energetic, troublesome, remembering the days when I was less than 2 years old, still crawling, and would reach into the living room fireplace to set it alight. I was 9 years old, folding into the outside wall of my elementary school, unfolding my Nintendo DSi XL and beginning to play Mario Kart since I was too god-awful to last more than a round or two in a game of lightning or four-square.

No, I wasn't 9. And it wasn't quite like that—when I was 9, my friend whose parents divorced and dad took him to Nevada would put himself onto a plane to go halfway across the country to see me. Me, the person who invited him to stay at his house for a week when they were both 7 and his parents left town for a time. No, it wasn't me who said that—it was our parents, the ones who debated telling us the real reason we had a week-long sleepover in the middle of the school year, who decided that they got along well-enough during hockey practice, despite only knowing each other for a month or two, that they would enjoy this time a hell of a lot better than the rest of the occasional agents of free will would. Who? The one you don't think about anymore, the one you thought was the most important person in your life for a couple months, a couple years, a couple decades just until a switch was flipped and some latent ionizing energy ripped your bonds to shreds, bonds so essential, so *innate* that your capacity to reason, to memory, was put on sabbatical[1, 2]. Still, in memory, everything is something else entirely.

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[1] Computer processors are silicon wafers whose atoms are arranged into two-dimensional lattice-structures with energy valleys separating peaks. Essentially, the valley is the lack of latent, background energy you would expect at any given point. When a switch is flipped, however, energy is rocketed up the valley and onto the peaks which is the start of how a computer comes to "reason." The ghost in the machine? It was you all along.

[2] By contrast, the neurons in each of our brains remain at a state of negative charge until they are excited by the nearest neuron—but only after it, in turn, is excited by something else. Computers think in a binary contrast of nothing and something, 0 and 1—i.e., a charge existing or not—but a human brain? we think in terms of positive

Now, some years later, he is deafeningly obvious as you are sometimes greeted with the memory of his texts talking about "killing towelheads." No, it wasn't that—he put a hyphen between the towel and head, right? Was it a text or was it on Instagram? A post? A story? Was it the video games? Or maybe that last conversation you had in the car with him before he shipped out, maybe it was the fantasies you always knew were there, during his last visit to what was one of two true homes for him. No. He didn't think like that—in truth, he loathed seeing his mom, and he resented every moment he spent with her. But he did it for you.

A cell and its walls are porous points of exchange, two-sided double-walled boundaries with a number of bars and windows where a trickle can cascade in, where a neutral resting-state can happen, like a cell, like a neuron—always resting negatively; open, still, like a neutral core, like skin. That's it…

Still, his voice, your voice—the smile, the laugh. Still, who is on the other's mind? Who remembers whose idea it was to tell the other to strip naked? I certainly don't.

It was at his home—that, I remember. The walls, the ceiling, the difference in temperature from one moment to the next, the border of his closet door flirting with the seam of wall and ceiling, the empty top bunk, the bottom uninhabited except for when he'd place me there, lay me[3].

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and negative, between –1, and 1, an additional infinity between the two. This is all in a network of about 100 billion individual neurons, which is to say that EEG machines are listening to a lot of noise. But what's the ghost in the machine here? The machine itself? Well, what happened seconds to minutes, hours to days, or weeks to months, years, millennia before this reason was put on sabbatical and that reason took the opening?

[3] I'm walking through a park; I need to catch my breath. It's something about the situation, the thickness of the air, the memory of his voice, perhaps. Maybe it's because I closed my eyes that the memory is happening to me, maybe. Did I? Was it me? It couldn't be. No, it couldn't be. I, like many of us, had a kind of perversion (in a sense) but not like that, I would never do that. Would I?

That, *that* is what home is—still. But it's easy to say such things in vacuums, on peaks. Ships get torn down, rebuilt. I take for granted how fortunate I was, how fortunate any of us are today. When we look at what happens to us—really, it's everything; everything does—we take that for granted too, how ingenious the whole rememory, the history, story, the whole latitude, the breadth, instantaneous shuttering, the blinds, the ripples of skin on skin, an angel, a devil, a metaphor like "time is a flat circle" or the neurons that formulate them, the hands that put formulae together, the fingers that grip the pens that write them down, a shattered self, a block that begins a foundation, a dripping faucet fading into the background, the light that slowly spills in in the early hours when old reruns or infomercials turn into regularly-scheduled programming, the original Scooby-Doo series on DVD; and, finally, a needle dropped in an empty auditorium.

Haunted to this day:

Memories float adrift like digital photos without metadata—the information encoded beneath the pixels that tell you the where, when and how an instant was recorded. Whenever a picture is taken, you can tell which specific camera took it, what lens was used, and what date and time the camera was set to. Things aren't so neat for us—we rip apart our photos like we can't be bothered to move them from one home to another, so we shred them. This is how ghosts are made—from scattered memories, dissolved instances.

First Lecture:

There is one thing that you should take from this course—that is that virtually everything is emergent of something else. In our current age, it is impossible to tell this for sure, but we can be fairly certain that there is no absolute cause for something, no underlying structure, invisible to any sort of measurement, that magically explains everything magical in the world. To avoid being too abstract, too arcane, and noting that this is ultimately a discussion about the emergence of language, I'll just go ahead and say that the notion of Universal Grammar, the Chomskian notion that *Language* is innate and modular, and that language knowledge and language learning is insular, that we are endowed with the capacity to language—and *that* is how we learn to language so well—is complete and utter nonsense. From the outset, Chomsky, himself, argued that *I-language,* the internal cognitive phenomena that bring about the expression of language, is not accessible to observation, that it is an abstract system of relations, a mere construct. Moreover, that the languages that exist in the world, in all their incredible variability, are *epiphenomena* of this internal system—read, not of interest to the study of linguistics (Chomsky, 1986, 2015). This is not what we do in empirical studies, this is not what we, as scientists, should be interested in unless there is some strong philosophical preference (which is not a scientifically motivated reason) (Roslyn M. Frank et al., 2008; Tom Ziemke et al., 2007). If we want to reach any valuable generalization about human language, in any and all of its forms—which should be the goal of linguistics if it were to be treated as a serious science—the *first* thing on our agenda should be to study the variety of human languages. Thus, it is not the scientific study of Language, linguistics, I mean, but rather, as Enrique Bernárdez puts it, the scientific study of *languages*—"in the plural"—for every and all of their beautiful variations, the variability in their use from one language to another, one generation to another, one culture or region to another,

one person to another is what drew us—any of us—to study such a thing in the first place; to wonder at the fact that this language uses a subject-object-verb word order, or that one sentences words to be sentences, or this one uses one word in about a million different ways—or uses a million different words to express what we might put under the umbrella of love—or, in my favorite example, that Spanish uses *idioma* [iðiomə] to refer to the specific instance of a language, a dialect, an idiolect, where English speakers might say "capital L language".The not-so-incorrect equivalent is the word *idiom,* which originally derives from the Greek word *idioma,* meaning "a peculiar phraseology" which, itself, comes from the root *idios,* meaning "personal, private, particular to oneself." This is where things get interesting—that an idiom is a personal, private language, particular to oneself. That self should be the forefront of social science research, that relations between self and language, self and other, self and self, self and community, environment, idiom—that all of these relations are reckoned, articulated in the idioms one carries around with them, negotiated, renegotiated, remapped—all of that is of interest. Now, how does this all come to be? Well, first, you have to have the ability to perceive things—and we evolved the necessary organs to do so a few million years ago. Next, there needs to be a complex organ system that allows for speech sounds to be articulated in perceptually salient ways. Sounds are simple enough, but complex sounds? Sound simple enough? Really, few things are as complex as this—for something to be "perceptually salient", for example, quite a few conditions need to be met—but that is for a different section entirely. First, speech organs[4]. We can be fairly certain these things *really* developed when the Great Apes came onto the scene, but didn't really get as sophisticated as they are now until about five-hundred to six-hundred

[4] By "first", I mean "first after a couple billion years' worth of amino acid development, cell development, complex organism development. For that matter, two billion years after planet formation, a few billion years after star formation, a few billion years after star death, a few billion years after star life, and several billion years after endless clouds of superheated hydrogen and helium. Before that? nobody knows."

thousand years ago (Fitch et al., 2016). Then, or maybe meanwhile, or perhaps before, we have the ability to distinguish between sounds in the 20-20,000 Hz range, and discriminate between pitches in the 1 Hz range among those sounds, meaning that we can tell the difference in pitch between 120 Hz and 121 Hz. And then[5] we develop the ability to learn things, to learn that cold weather follows falling leaves, that a person showing me their teeth can mean either happiness or anger, that red berries can taste sweet but black berries sometimes kill people—and they're more bitter (just an example, don't quote me on the systematicity of that). Some time after this[6] comes the ability to associate cause with effect, to associate one thing with another and, thus, to associate the closure of one's lips followed by the vocalization and eventual opening [ma] as meaning you, the person they are looking at, just as you did your mother. This means they need your attention, no longer are they screaming and wailing and crying—they can notify you, directly. This is much more efficient, and we have cared about efficiency for a few hundred thousand years at this point. I see I've gone over time; let's stop here.

[5] Or perhaps before, meanwhile, after—all at once.
[6] Almost definitely after

Seminar:

I could sit here and continue to lecture at you for the rest of the time we both have, but we only have so much time—and we can only expect so much out of strangers—so I'll drop most of the façade and give you some flesh to sink your teeth into, a few things to chew on, a few embodied loops and functions to interact with…

I want you to take me and rend me into something else entirely. I want you to labor over the mutability of my body, my skin and adorn me in your best-dressed garb as you take on the artifice of best-dressed bard, a model in Beverly Hills wearing nothing under their dress, the surprising smoothness of entrails as you disembowel your comrade. I want you to imagine how I would imagine myself in another language, how I might be squeezed through the pores of concrete bricks and sucked out the other side by a thirsty worm looking to consume the best tasting rot.

I want to not take for granted what I am rendered from, what invisible yet measurable force brought about my existence. I want to be a counterargument for mind-body dualism. I want to be thought of by one, you, as an accompaniment to a piece for a *rebec* followed, after a few measures, by a *guitarra moresca* where, 500 years from now, a hopeful young lad is unsure if you are supposed to be a man or a woman—or if that even matters so long as he feels contented. A sole, exclusive standard, my eyes pressed tight to cold glass, a hand tracing a spine, a cover, a shiver as a leaf cuts your finger. The realization that all art is just different people fingering different things until they come to the realization that nothing they see with their familiar eyes will ever be familiar again. Your eyes after you hear me begin to speak, the way you excitedly

embraced me after a year abroad. A book slamming shut, a poem hanging on the breath of someone as they blow it into their coffee to cool it down, an exasperated sigh. You learning my language, my sole, exclusive, private and idiotic idiom just to be able to know me as I am, something you would only expect from a future spouse or a really really good friend. A labor of love that, at best, will go mostly unnoticed and, at worst, be under even more intense scrutiny than if it hadn't been done at all. Somewhere in between there is a transgression that incites a revolution—because nobody can ever tell if those are wholly good or evil. What does it feel to be known? What it feels to be situated, regardless of culture, regardless of what one's particular body appears as at a particular moment, phenomenological running-off, remembrance of things past, mutation, mutability, certainty, an "I love you" followed by "stupid."[7]

[7] I was once embarrassed, maybe ashamed. Maybe I still am, I don't know. Maybe it was being awestruck. It's not like it matters to anyone anyway—I would just hate to leave things so bitterly, since I took the time to learn your language, but not your idiom. I was pressed, an orange being processed into juice—would that make you the pulp discarded? I don't want to think so for even one of my favorites said "Look! Aren't you amazing? Aren't you beautiful! I can picture you two together and nothing else!" and that was all she was able to say on the matter. The *Engel* in me was reminded of the *Engel* in you. I could never not agree for you are proof that the real is more mystifying and strange than anything else. Really, the real is the prototypical strange.

Second Lecture:

How is it that I can make you know what I know? It's quite a simple question, really, and it has a simple answer—I can tell you things. But how do I know that what I am about to tell you is understandable to you? Well, we can talk for a little bit and prove to each other that we happen to share this mode of communication and, through a lot of data, we can assess and corroborate our understanding of the world and various topics of discussion through this system. So then the question is how do we happen to share this? And then we can go on and talk about the age of English imperialism and establish how the language came to become the global Lingua Franca. But, then, what that elucidates is that the only reason we happen to share this mode of communication, which happens to be English in this case, is because English is a socially, economically and politically important language for us to know, and that the reason we, as individuals, happen to know it is because the various social, economic and political situations that we or our predecessors found ourselves or themselves in were ones that were particularly conducive or caused a situation for necessitating knowledge of English which was then, more or less, imposed upon them or learned. So let's return to the original question: how is it that I can make you know what I know? The answer is that we share a language and the reason we share that language is that it is a useful one to know. But what if we didn't? And let's make it even more extreme—what if we didn't share a language with *anybody.* We spoke our own idiomatic isolates that nobody else could understand. What would happen then? I figure that one of five things often happen in this situation, (1) we kill each other (2) I learn your language (3) you learn my language (4) we both learn a third language or (5) we engage in so much contact with one another that our distinct languages blend into a new language. There is one basic and essential reason for (2) through (5) happening, because the situation we find ourselves in requires us to

interact with each other in meaningful ways. In other words, shared languages are necessary for social engagement and, by proxy, social integration, economic integration, political engagement and all the other social institutions you can name. We can go even more basic than that and say that humans are often confronted with problems that they cannot solve by themselves. In order to solve these problems together, humans need to communicate things about these problems in ways that are able to be understood by the other human. Yet another problem. The solution to that problem is that we come to associate phonetic forms with meaning or representation. Basically, these sounds I make with my vocal tract represent certain objects of experience and, eventually, concrete and abstract meanings. Then, the next basic thing is that this needs to be conventionalized, meaning that we need to keep the rules of this mode of communication consistent so that all of us can remember them and we don't miscommunicate so much. And then, over time, a language happens. It is a solution to a problem, the solution being a systematic repurposing of cognitive faculties and the organs of your vocal tract[8] to conduct, coordinate and socialize with other Great Apes that have an unusually large cranial mass. The next question might, then, be "why is this something that we did and other humans didn't?" Well, take Neanderthals, who had larger brains that we did, but there is no evidence of them having language. The key difference between us and them is that our social organizations were presumed to be much more sophisticated than theirs. So, they likely didn't have the social needs or abilities to conventionalize the form-meaning pairings that language tends to be in order to make it stick. Basically, it wasn't trendy enough for all the Neanderthals to adopt it. Note that this doesn't mean they didn't have language—as far as I know, we don't have evidence either

[8] Note that each of these serves a function that is non-linguistic: teeth and tongues are used for eating, the lungs are used for breathing, the nasal cavity for sensation (and all are used for loving someone), etc. even the vocal cords are found in animals that don't speak.

way—they very well could have had some ways to refer to objects of experience or concepts. I'm partial to the idea that they probably did have some kind of linguistic system because all the parts were there. It just likely didn't have the idiosyncrasies that Sapient language has because of how their social circles were likely organized and, therefore, it didn't take off before they were eradicated by our distant ancestors. The incredible thing about living today is that—while we still have no idea—really, we need not rely so much on guessing.

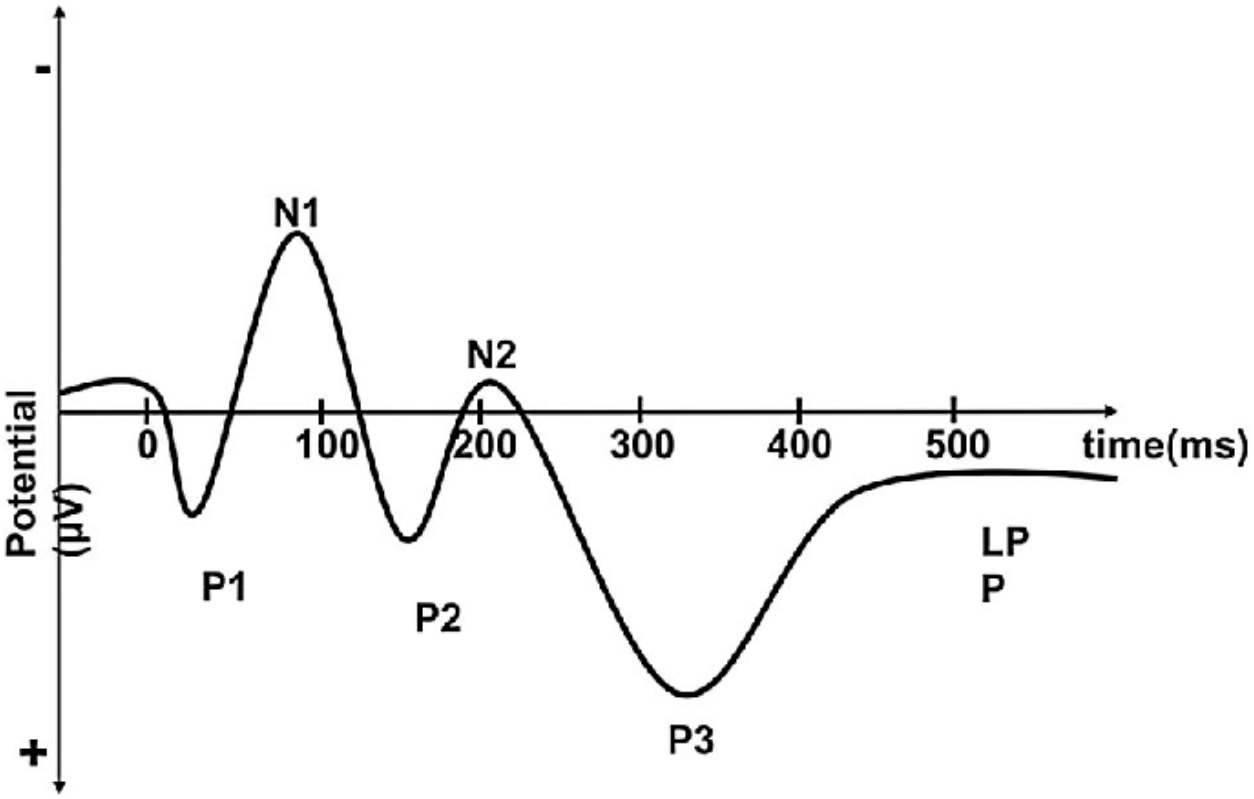


Fig 1: The event-related potentials of face perception captured using electroencephalography.

Socio:

Take Korean, for instance. Currently, we are seeing a shift in two of the three categories in its obstruent consonants. They are starting to become more similar in younger speakers. Korean has three types of stops: lenis, fortis and aspirated. These differ in both voice onset time (VOT) and the pitch (also called the fundamental frequency, or F0) of the following vowel. So, in order to tell which sound is which, a listener checks both for voicing and the pitch of the following vowel. However, it has been found that Korean speakers rely more on F0 than VOT when discriminating between two sounds. This process is called "cue weighting" and we see it in various cases all over the place. Recently, the lenis and aspirated sounds (which have intermediate-low VOT-F0 window and high-intermediate VOT-F0 window respectively) have been getting closer in VOT in younger generations of Korean speakers. So, the lenis sound is getting more aspirated in terms of VOT. This is just postulation, but I would presume that this would not have been the case if Korean listeners didn't weigh cues in the ways they do. So what does this mean? Languages change in certain ways because of added or removed pressures that force them to do certain things. Maybe a handful of Korean speakers in one speech community near Seoul over a few years realized that they were more likely to accurately distinguish sounds based on F0 than VOT, and they began emphasizing the F0 more to accommodate that and, over time, the VOT got longer and longer, and, because Seoul happened to be the cultural center of the country, this innovation spread so that everyone else could sound more "metropolitan" or something that suggests a group of humans all speaking like the last. This is assuming, there are a lot of uncertainties—but we must, *must* be comfortable accepting uncertainties, accepting the messiness of the world, of people, of their variability and gradience, the artifacts affecting their

memory, their focal lengths all changing, differing, rather than trying to formulate some unifying theory of essence that ties everything together.[9]

[9] That, and these very dynamics go back to Labov (1965) and Labov et al. (2006).

A Folk Theory of Essences:

When I was 18, I enrolled in a digital media production program at a local community college. While I didn't hate it, I realized pretty quickly that the whole thing wasn't for me. The shitty thing about that is that I only realized this after I dropped over a thousand dollars on a Sony a6100 mirrorless camera alongside a couple of lenses for the program. No bother, though, as I have since been able to repurpose it into my de facto Zoom camera for my makeshift home-office since transferring to the University of Iowa. Two of the lenses were included in the purchase—the wider-angle 16-50mm lens and the longer 55-210mm lens. I got another 28-70mm lens some months later for an assignment. The curious thing about these when looking at them is the gap between the location that connects to the body of the camera and the glass that initiates the actual lens portion. As with all things, there is significant variation, but this is in the distance light travels to



reach the retina of the camera, the shutter, what used to be a mirror, but is now a digital photoreceptor that initiates electrical signals when excited by photons, something vaguely human.

How long it has to pass-through, how much the light is bent and distorted, how much it is translated—this variation. I think about how looking in a mirror is an act of translation—in the literal sense that the image of your face is transferred into yourself—which is an inherent impossibility. The lens changes the shape and inherent properties of the image of whatever they are pointing to. The dog across the street is never the same size relative to itself or the rest of the scene if every pointing is done with a different camera, with a different zoom, with a different lens. This is a truism. But what is perhaps even more curious to me is what happens when you take the



lens off the camera and look through the viewfinder. There is a vague sense of color, of colorlessness, of tone, of mood, of gradience—with distinctively shaded or shadowed things, there may even be a shape. What is this bare impression? What some might call “pure knowledge” for some reason? How does it come to be? Really, the structure that captures the image is rather unassuming—a black slate of darkness, tessellated with sensors that take in the variable attenuation of light waves and converts them into an image that can be processed, read by a human. The reason

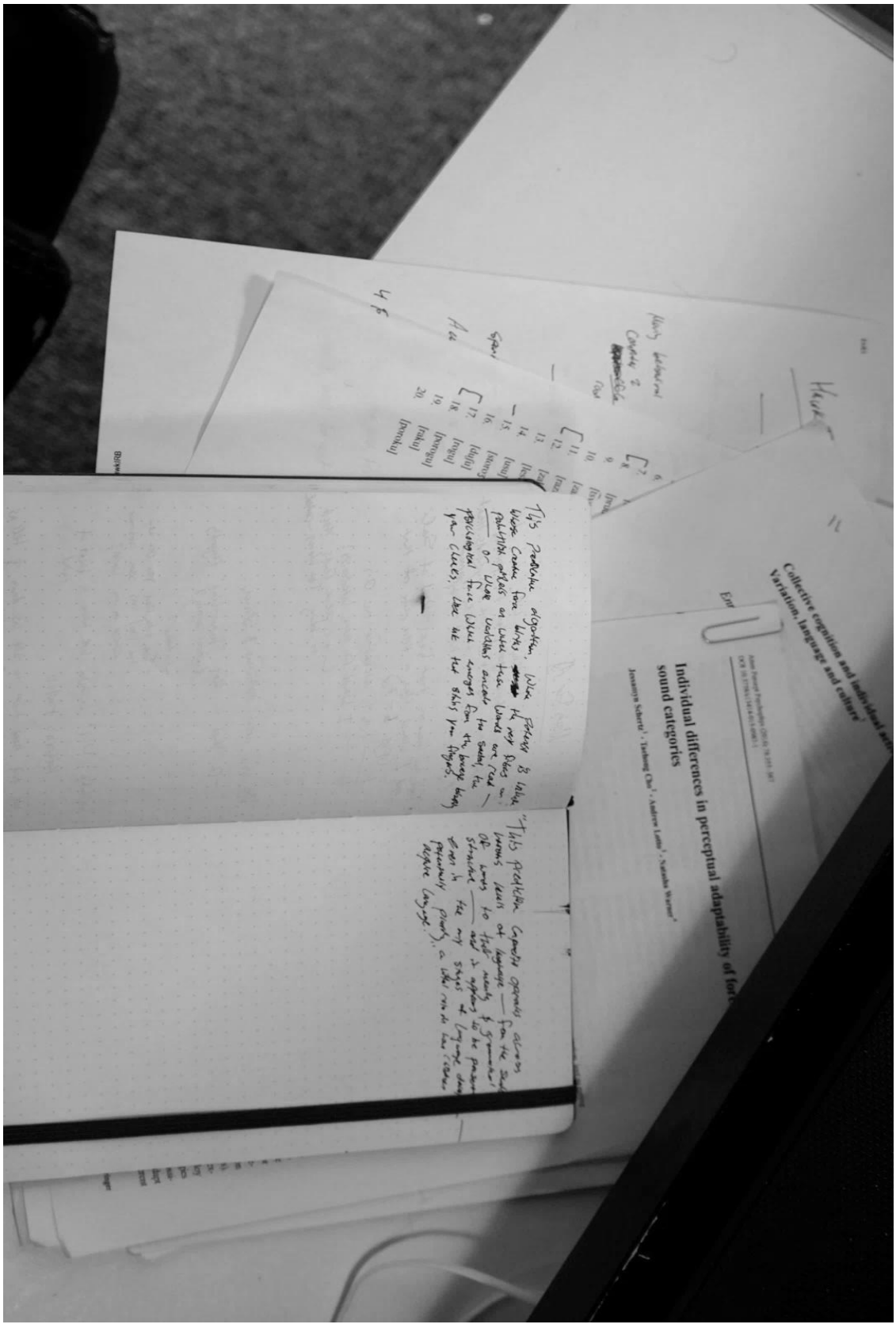
it's blurry is because the light needs to hit the receptor at a specific angle in order for it to be clear—something with no human analogue because we are never without the lenses in our eyes. It's like when a car passes through fog, the light diffused into a vague blur in every direction. In a pinch, it is possible to, as I have, take two pieces of paper, aluminum, plastic—anything flat, really—and punch two holes in them to create a makeshift lens. The first one must be closest to the camera, right up against the body of it, and a few millimeters in diameter. The second one



should be right on top of that and nothing more than a pinhole. Here, I took a photo of the stack of books about to be falling off my desk using a paper gift bag, fibers still clouding the image's judgement, a splash of color bringing light to life, a phantom in the upper-left quadrant. Curious, really. But, really, when you remove all focusing apparatuses, what you see is nothing, a tabula rasa. It is pure language, the uncanniness of attending a reading or a church service in a language you don't know a lick of, or of reading through a list of unrelated noun phrases, passing by rooms unemptied—seeing images of restaurants you've never been to on Google Maps, knowing that the

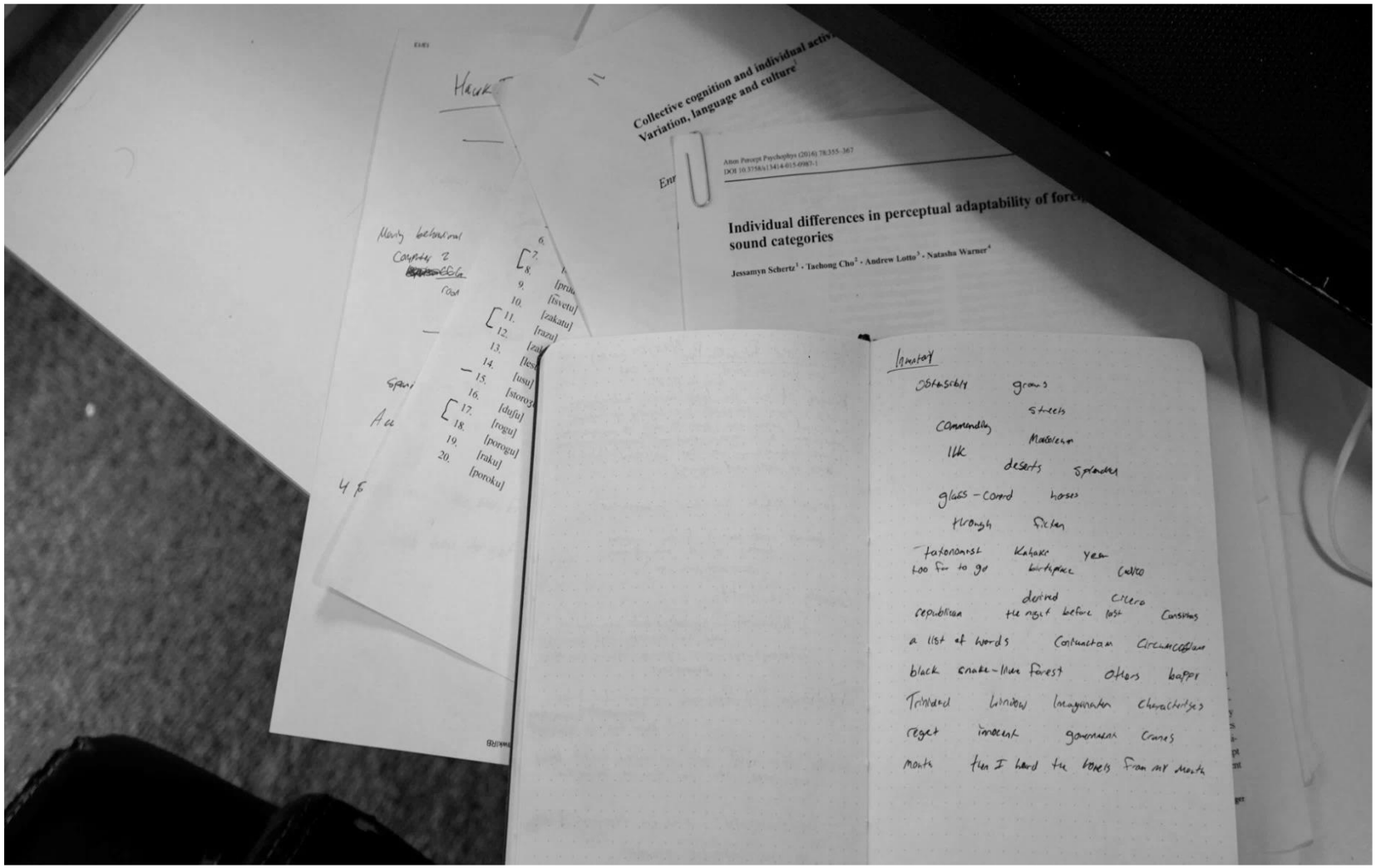
people there were living lives blissfully unaccompanied by the awareness of a gazing eye. This is pure language—the opportunity one has to always grasp but to also always slip. The shapes are there, the colors are there, but what is missing is the translational bending of light to make them into an image worth seeing, a texture, a ground, a focus. In this state, there is only gradience, numbness, there is only the universe, a sigh. There is no folk theory of essences: in every new image, in every new sight, sign, sense—there is, beneath, between and behind it, the dissolution of its properties, a gradient. What is audio if not a clamor of sounds tuned to sensibility and killing off the noise? Sight without a lens to focus it, sight without sound, a written word without a auditory phoneme to link it to, a gesture—the suggestion that it has meaning, the pauses, the rhythm, the timbre with no conceptual bases—a resting potential before a trigger, the ninety-nine percent of your visual space out of focus, the partitions of language, the delta between *etic* and *emic,* or something and nothing*,* neurally networked to various structures of the brain, unlit.

Papyrus


Collective cognition and individual
Variation, language and culture
Individual differences in perceptual adaptability of
sound categories

This predictive algorithm, whose potency is infinite, whose creative force births the very fibres on which this is being read—or whose variations encode the social, the psychological force which emerges from the breeze brushing your cheeks, or gently plucking and strumming the summer leaves, like ink that stains your fingers. A phoneme in birdsong.

“This predictive capacity operates across various levels of language—from the sounds of words to their meaning & grammatical structure—and it appears to be present even in the early stages of language development—potentially playing a vital role in how children acquire language.”


Collective cognition and individual activ
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Jessamyn Schertz · Taehong Cho · Andrew Lotto · Natasha Warner
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year
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republican
desired
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Cicero
lost
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a list of words
Continuation
black snake - like
forest
others
happy
Trinidad
window
imagination
characterizes
regret
innocent
government
cranes
mouth
then I heard the bones from my mouth

Inventory

Ostensibly *groans*

Commanding *streets*

Ilk *Mausoleum*

deserts *splendor*

glass-covered *horses*

through fiction, all things are real

too far to go *taxonomist* *kahaki* *year*

derived *codico*

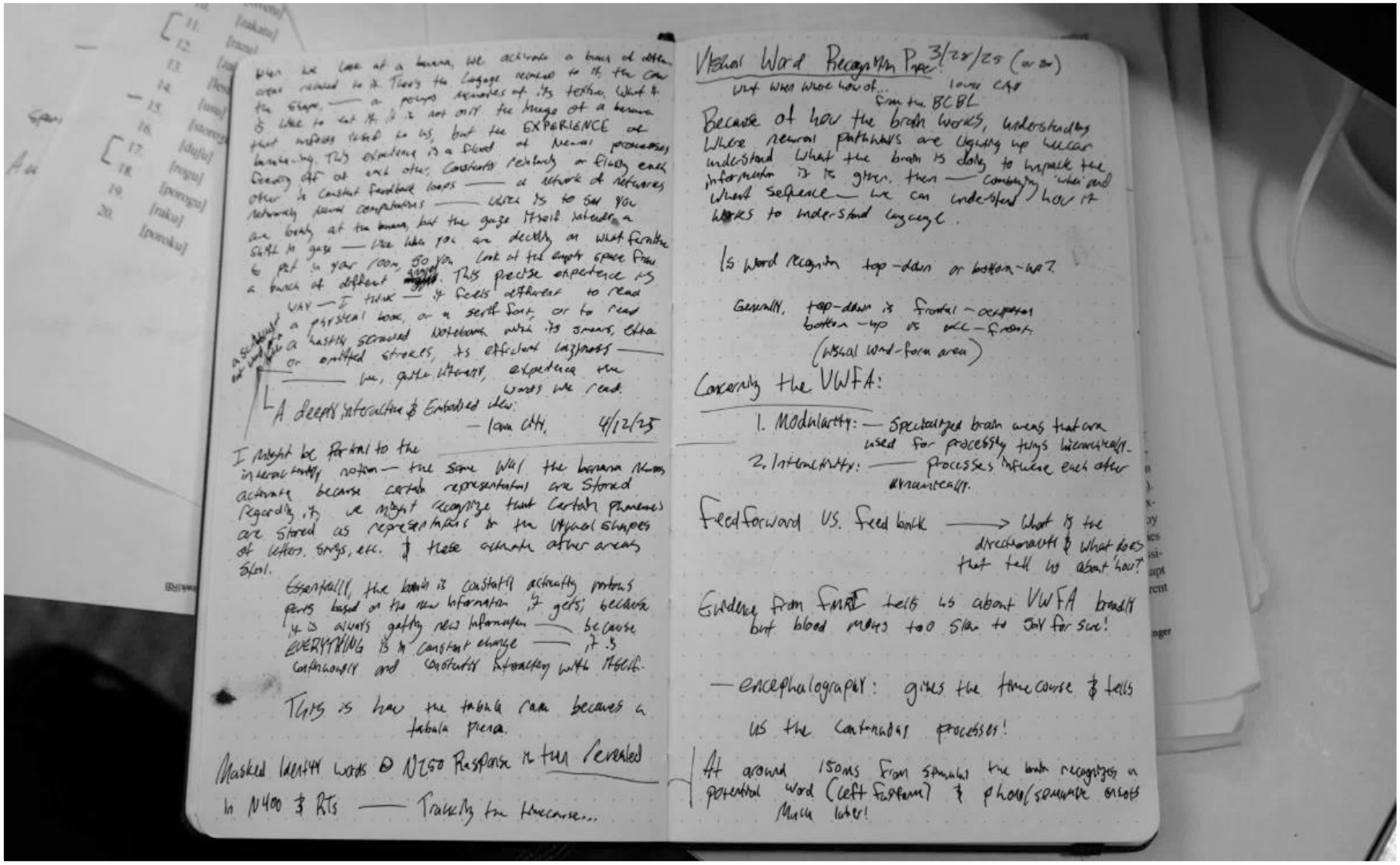
republican *the night before last* *cicero*

a list of words *conjunction* *circumlocution*

black, snake-like forests *others* *happiness in Trinidad* *regret*

windows, glossy unerring windows *innocence* *government* *cranes*

my mouth *then I heard the vowels from my mouth*



When we look at a banana, we activate a bunch of other areas related to it. Things the language related to it, the color, — a person describes of its texture. What it tastes like to eat it. It is not only the image of a banana that matters to us, but the EXPERIENCE of banana-ing. This experience is a blend of neural processes feeding off of each other. Constantly relating or fitting each other in constant feedback loops — a network of networks networking neural computations — which is to say you are looking at the banana, but the gaze itself intended a sight to gaze — like how you are deciding on what furniture to get in your room. So you look at the empty space from a bunch of different [illegible]. This precise experience as you — I think — it feels different to read a physical book, or a serifs font, or to read a hastily scrawled notebook note with its smears, extra or omitted strokes, its efficient laziness — — — — me, quite literally, experience the words we read.

— A deeply interactive & Embodied idea:
— Iowa City, 4/12/25

I might be partial to the interactivity notion — the same way the banana neurons activate because certain representations are stored. Regardless, it's we might recognize that certain phonemes are stored as representations in the visual shapes of letters, strings, etc. & these activate other areas also.

Essentially, the brain is constantly activating patterns/parts based on the new information it gets, because it is always getting new information — because EVERYTHING is in constant change — it is continuously and constantly interacting with itself.

This is how the tabula rasa becomes a tabula plena.

Masked identity words & N250 Response is then reversed in N400 & RTs — Tracking the timecourse...

Visual Word Recognition Paper: 3/28/25 (or so)
what when where how of... from the BCBL

Because of how the brain works, understanding where neural pathways are lighting up we can understand what the brain is doing to unpack the information it is given. then — combining 'what' and 'when' sequence — we can understand how it works to understand language.

Is word recognition top-down or bottom-up?

Generally, top-down is frontal-occipital
bottom-up is occ-frontal.
(visual word-form area)

Concerning the VWFA:

1. Modularity: — Specialized brain areas that are used for processing things interactively.
2. Interactivity: — processes influence each other dynamically.

Feedforward vs. feedback ——> What is the directionality & what does that tell us about 'how'?

Evidence from fMRI tells us about VWFA broadly but blood moves too slow for our size!

— encephalography: gives the time course & tells us the continuous processes!

At around 150ms from stimulus the brain recognizes a potential word (left fusiform) & phonological/semantic errors much later!

Concerning the VWFA:

The Visual Word-Form Area: The Left Fusiform Gyrus—

When we look at a banana, we activate a bunch of other areas in our brains related to it. There's the language related to it, the color, the shape—or perhaps memories of its texture, what it is like to eat it. It is not only the image of the banana that unfolds itself to us, but the EXPERIENCE of banana-ing. This experience is entangled in all of these cognitive properties that are activated and thus manifest themselves in some way when looking at it. The experience is a flood of neural processes that are constantly feeding off of each other, constantly reinventing or fluxing each other in constant feedback loops—a network of networks networking neural computations—which is to say you are looking at the banana, but the gaze itself intends a more holistic experience of the object of your gaze, or even a shift in gaze—like when you're deciding which furniture will occupy an empty room, so you walk around the vacant space to see if from a bunch of different angles—you are rooming your imagination so that the room can embody itself around the more ready-at-hand image of a couch in an IKEA showroom. This precise experience is why—I think—it feels different to read a physical book as opposed to a sans serif font, or to read a hastily scribbled notebook long after its progenitor has passed, with its scribbles and smears, extra or omitted lines, a mistaken stroke, its efficient laziness—we, quite literally, experience the words, the letters, the phrases we read.

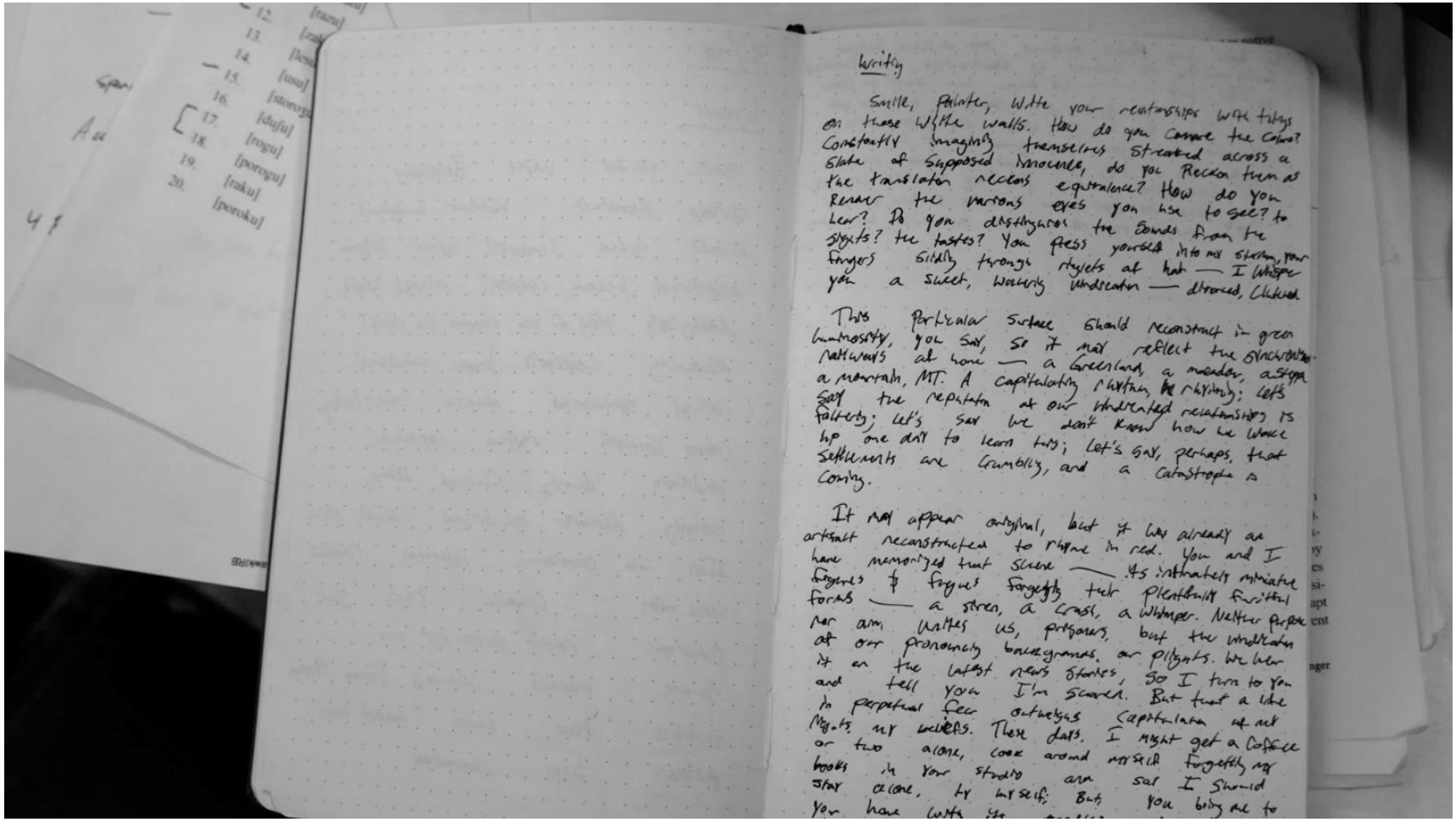
A deeply interactive & embodied view:

– Iowa City, April 12, 2025

N250 – masked identity revealed N400 – fully integrated, embodied

(Carreiras et al., 2014).

This is the way the tabula rasa becomes the tabula plena.

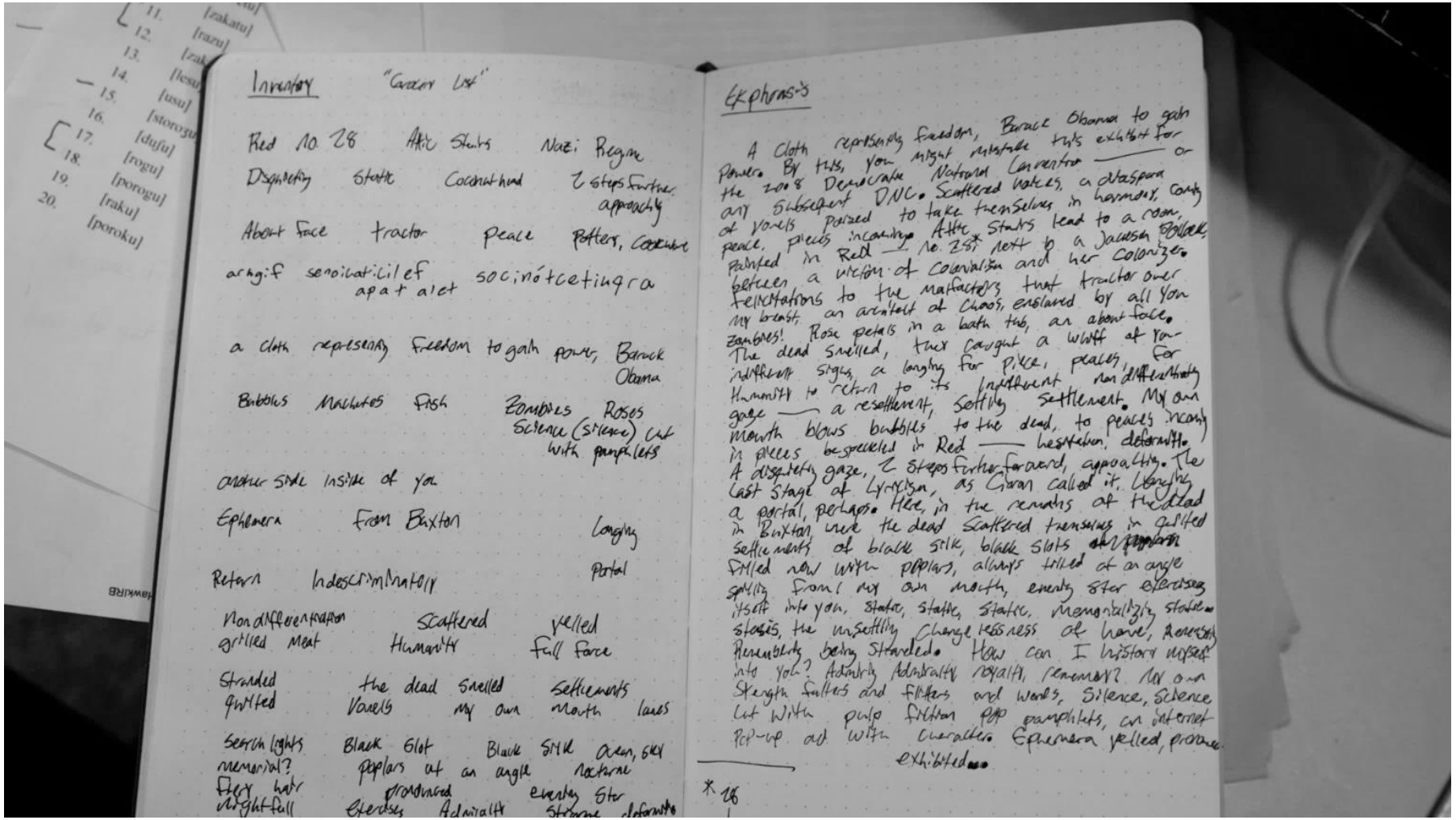

12. [razu]
13. [zak
14. [kesu
15. [usu]
16. [utoroyo
17. [dufu]
18. [rogu]
19. [porogu]
20. [raku]
[poroku]
Writing
Smile, painter, with your relationships with things
on those white walls. How do you compare the colors?
Constantly imagining themselves streaked across a
slate of supposed innocence, do you reckon them as
the translation reckons equivalence? How do you
render the various eyes you use to see? to
hear? Do you distinguish the sounds from the
sights? the tastes? You press yourself into our stories, your
fingers wildly strange objects at hand — I whisper
you a sweet, watery benediction — divorced, clicked
This particular surface should reconstruct in green
luminosity, you say, so it may reflect the structures
networks at home — a Greenland, a meander, a stigma
a mountain, MT. A capitulating rhythm, the rhythm; let's
say the reputation of our interrelated relationships is
faltering; let's say we don't know how we wrote
up one day to learn this; let's say, perhaps, that
settlements are crumbling, and a catastrophe is
coming.
It may appear original, but it was already an
artifact reconstructed to rhyme in red. You and I
have memorized that scene — its instruments miniature
fingers & tongues forgetfully their placeholder fricatival
forms — a stress, a crash, a whimper. Neither perfect
nor arm, unlike us, prepared, but the modulation
of our pronouncing boustrophedons, our pilgrims. We hear
it on the latest news stories, so I turn to you
and tell you I'm scared. But trust a like
in perpetual fear outweighs capitulation of our
rights, our beliefs. These days, I might get a coffee
or two alone, look around myself forgetfully my
books in your studio are sad I should
stay alone, by myself. But you bring me to
you have with

Smile, painter, for this is the way the world ends.

3/29

Inventory

Smile painter White Relationship
Surface Reconstruct Particular background
Should green Luminosity appear original
expressions became reddish? always White
disturbingly How do you compare the colors?
pronouncedly Constantly Imagine anticipation
railway synchronised absolute table-tennis
corner Corneved rhythm capitulate
Undeniably divorcee Clutched definitely
assigning deliberate memorized scene pierce
Ifell into conversation repetation ruthless
settlements Crumble tragic glut
Catastrophe neither purpose nor aim
narrative miniature intimately furnace Eternal
plentiful home needles camellia leaves
Prisoners Empty Consciousness


Inventory "Career List"
Red No. 28 Attic Stairs Nazi Regime
Dysentery Statue Coconut head 2 steps further, approach
About face tractor peace Potters, Cocaine
a cloth representing freedom to gain power, Barack Obama
Bubbles Machetes Fish Zombies Roses Science (silence) cut with pamphlets
another side inside of you
Ephemera From Buxton Longing
Return Indescriminately Portal
Non differentiation Scattered yelled
grilled Meat Humanity full force
Stranded the dead smelled Settlements
Gutted Vowels my own mouth lanes
Search lights Black Slot Black Silk ocean, sky
memorial? poplars at an angle nocturne
Ekphrasis
A cloth representing freedom, Barack Obama to gain Power. By this, you might mistake this exhibit for the 2008 Democratic National Convention ——— or any subsequent DNC. Scattered voices, a diaspora of vowels poised to take themselves in harmony, coming peace, pieces incoming. Attic stairs lead to a room, painted in Red ——— No. 28, next to a Jacuzzi filled with bodies, between a victim of colonialism and her colonizer. reflections to the manufactory that tractor over my breast, an architect of Chaos, enslaved by all you zombies! Rose petals in a bath tub, an about face. The dead smelled, they caught a whiff of your indifferent signs, a longing for piece, peaces, for Humanity to return to its indifferent non differentiating gaze ——— a resettlement, settling settlement. My own mouth blows bubbles to the dead, to peaces incoming in pieces, bespeckled in Red ——— hesitation, deformity. A dispatchy gaze, 2 steps further forward, approaching. The last stage of Lyricism, as Giran called it. Longing, a portal, perhaps. Here, in the remains of the dead in Buxton were the dead scattered themselves in gutted settlements of black silk, black slots [illegible] filled now with poplars, always tilted at an angle spilling from/ my own mouth, evenly ster ekerises, itself into you, Statue, Statue, Statue, Memorializing statue-stasis, the unsettling Changelessness of home, Recessed, Remembering, being Stranded. How can I historicize myself into you? Admiralty Admiralty royalty, remember? My own Strength falters and flutters and words, Silence, Silence, Cut With pulp fiction pop pamphlets, an internet Pop-up ad with characters. Ephemera yelled, pronounced, exhibited...
* 28

Ekphrasis

A cloth representing freedom, Barack Obama to gain power. By this, you might mistake this exhibit for the 2008 Democratic National Convention—or any subsequent DNC. Scattered voices, a diaspora of vowels poised to render themselves in(to) harmony, coming peace, pieces incoming. Attic stairs lead to a room painted in Red—no. 28[1] next to a Jackson Pollock, between a friend, a victim of colonialism, and her colonizer. Felicitations, fugues, nocturnes to the malefactors that tractor over my breast, an architect of chaos, enslaving us—enslaved by all you zombies! Rose petals in a bathtub, an about-face. The dead smelled—they caught a whiff of all your indifferent sighs, a longing for piece, peaces for Humanity to return to its indifferent, nondifferentiating fugue-gaze—a resettlement, settling settlement. My own mouth blows bubbles to the dead, to peaces incoming in pieces, bespeckled in Red—hesitation, deformity; certainty, unsettlement. A disquieting gaze, 2 steps futhrer, forward, approaching. The "Last Stage of Lyricism", as Cioran called it: a sigh, a wail—ultimate longing, or a portal, perhaps. Here, among the remains of Buxton where the dead scattered themselves in quilted settlements of black silk, black slits and slots filled now with poplars, always tilted at an angle unable to spill from my mouth or press into my eyes (Oort pressed unto my eyes pressed to porous glass), the evening star exercising itself into you, static, static, static—memorializing static. Stasis, the unsettling changelessness of home, remembering.

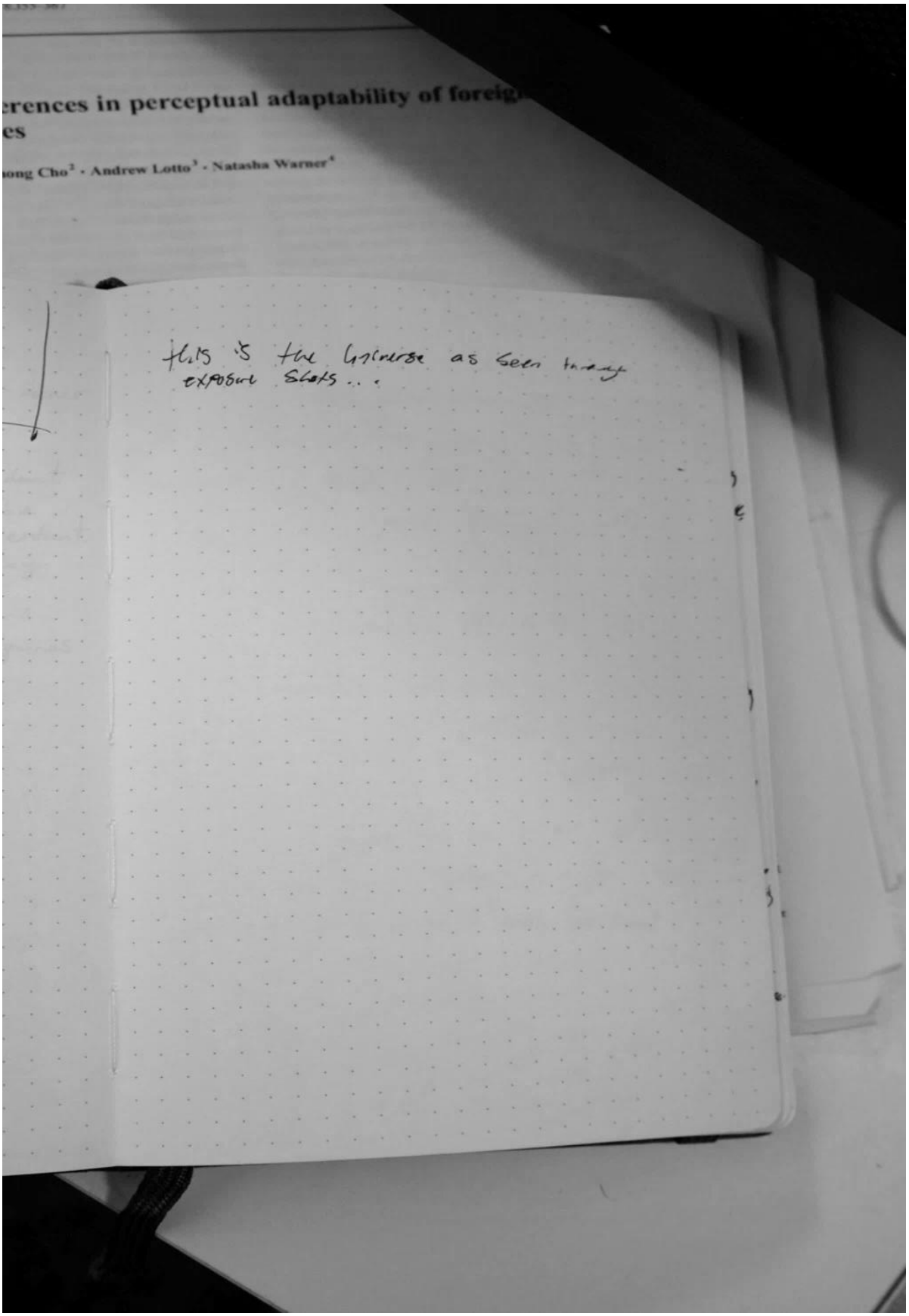
Remembering being stranded. How can I history myself into you? Admiring Admiralty, royalty, rememory? My own strength falters and flitters and wanes—silence, silence, science cut with pulp fiction pop pamphlets, an internet pop-up ad with a little more character. Ephemera yelled, pronounced,

Exhibited . . .

March 2025, IC

[1] 28
|
4n ——— a nazi regime ——— without wont to mince words

Everything at the end of time, one last gaze at the land being lost forever, the dog days of summer—


erences in perceptual adaptability of foreig
es
ong Cho[2] · Andrew Lotto[3] · Natasha Warner[4]
this is the universe as seen through
exposure shots...

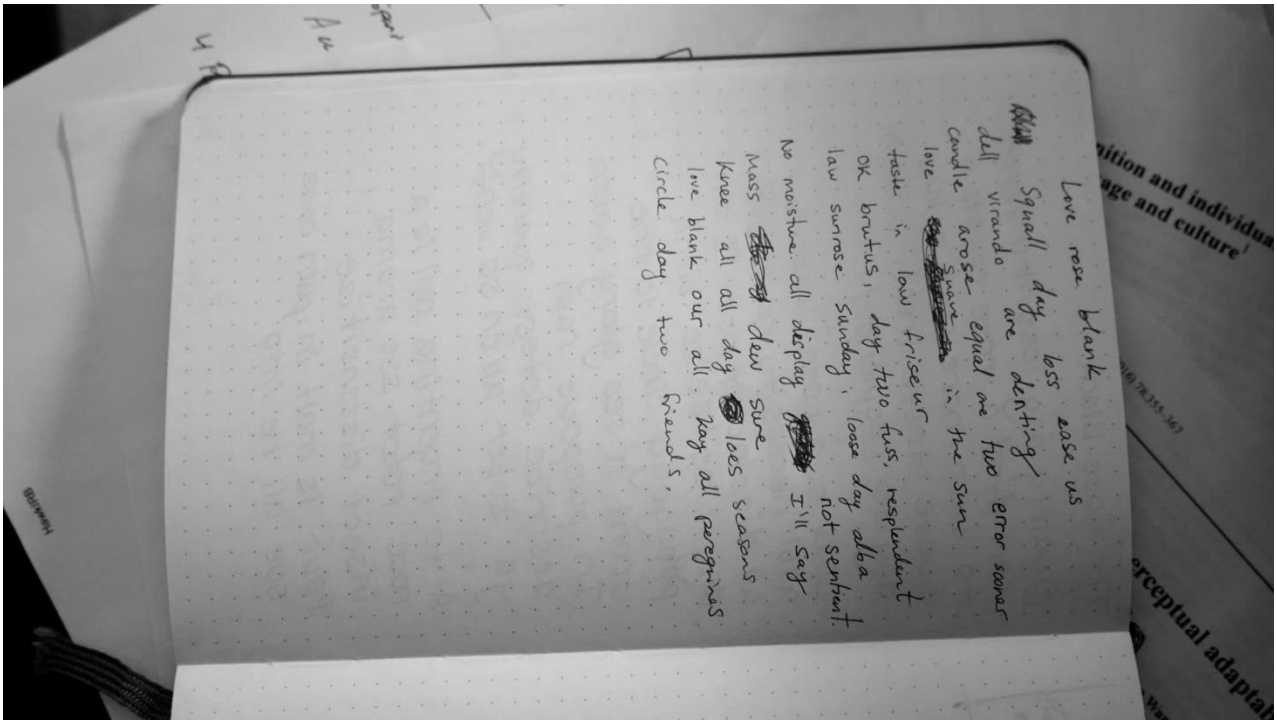
Scattered, scattered

approaching

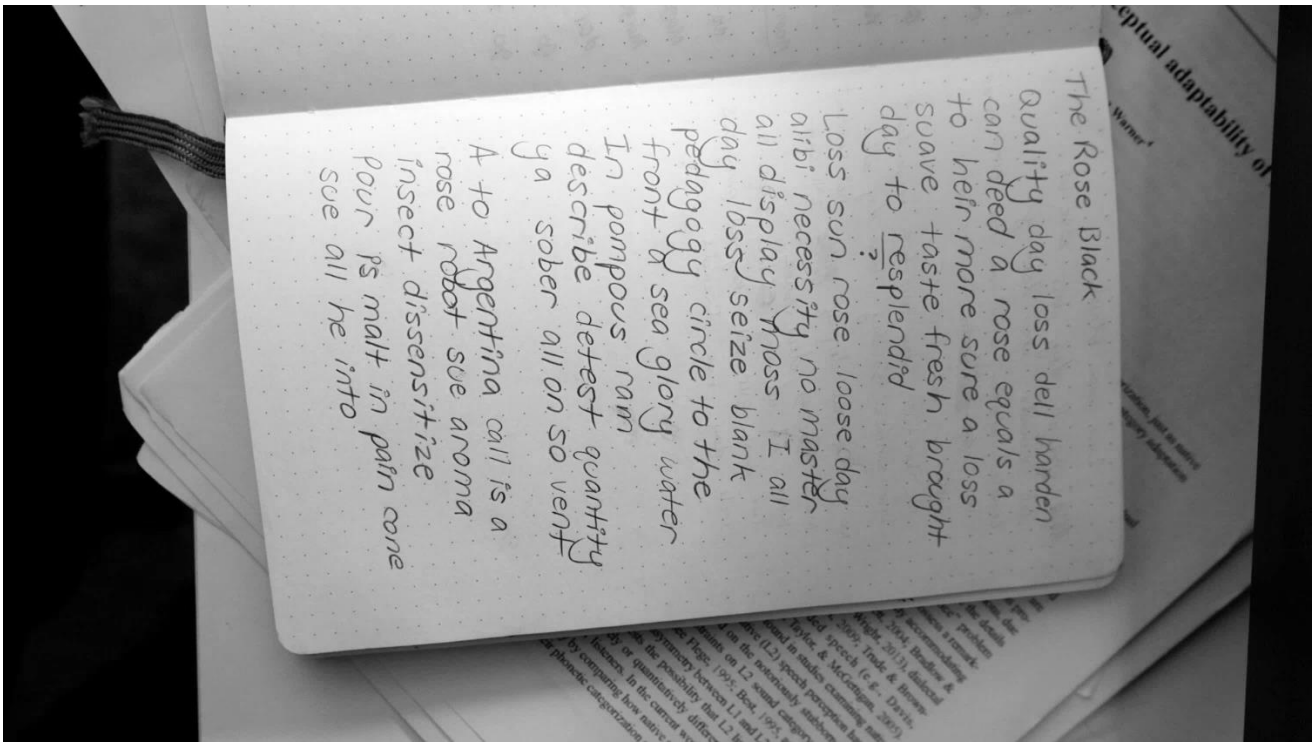
stealing,

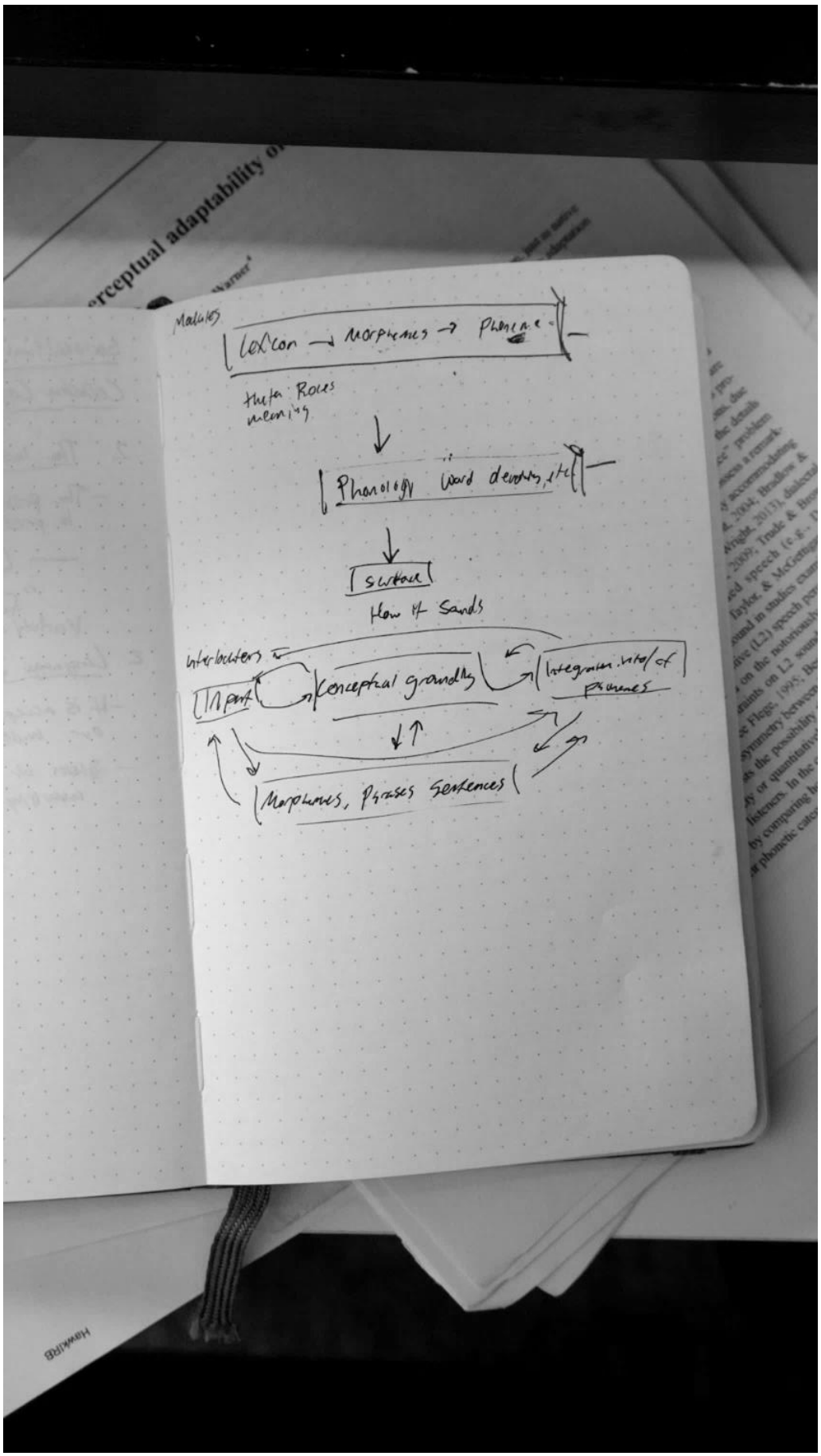
settling.

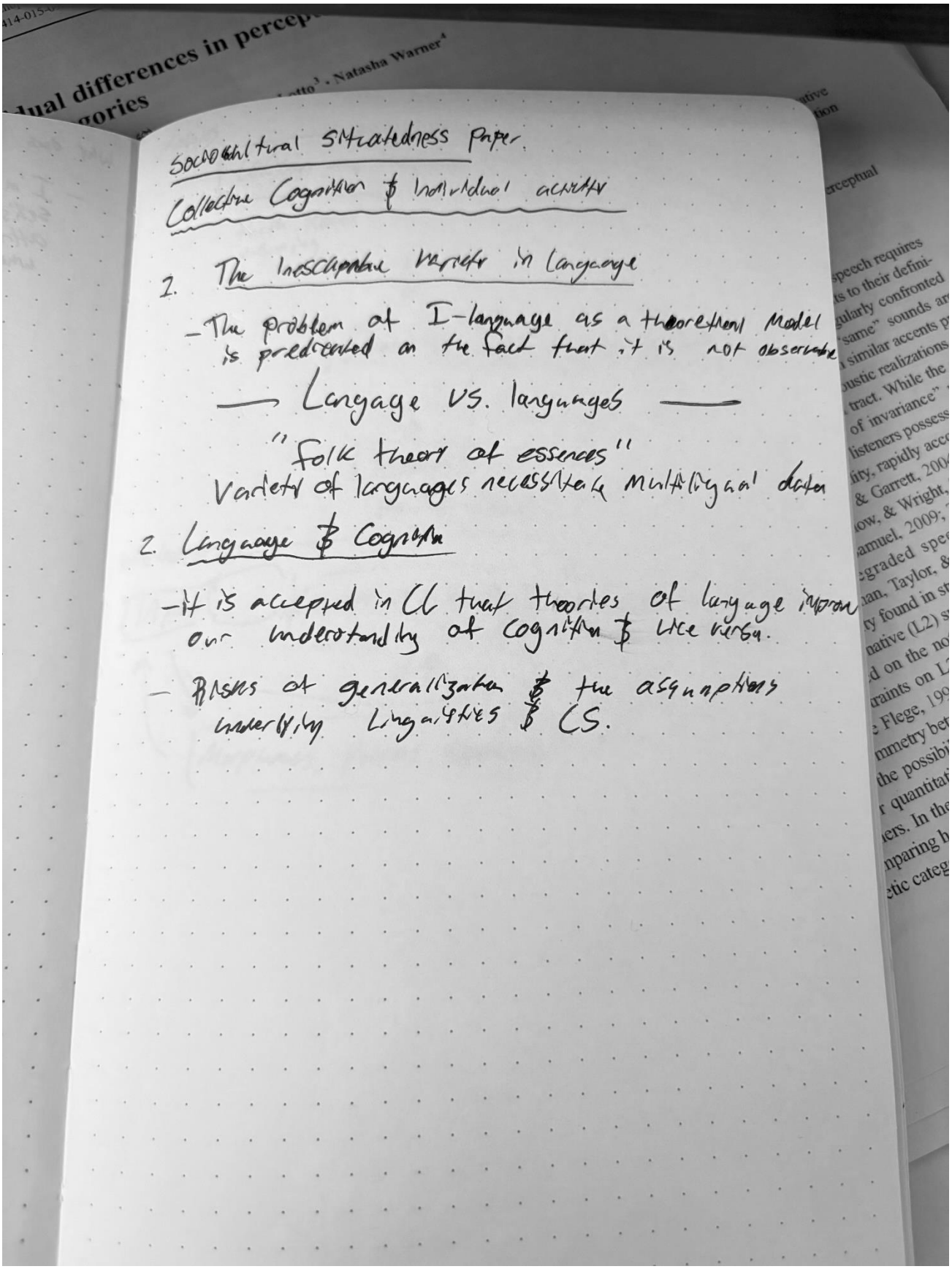
What is to world? What is to end but to transform, to remake, to render, to mutate?



interactive, shared, embodied, experienced




Lexicon → Morphemes → Phonemes
Theta Roles
meaning
Phonology word decoding, etc
Surface
How it sounds
Interlocutors
Input
Conceptual grounding
Integration into/of
Morphemes, Phrases Sentences



Sociocultural Situatedness Paper

Collective Cognition & Individual activity

1. The Inescapable Variety in Language

- The problem of I-language as a theoretical model is predicated on the fact that it is not observable

— Language vs. languages —

"folk theory of essences"

Variety of languages necessitates multilingual data

2. Language & Cognition

- It is accepted in CL that theories of language improve our understanding of cognition & vice versa.

- Basics of generalization & the assumptions underlying Linguistics & CS.

Collective cognition, individual variation, sociocultural situatedness—

the inescapable variety in the world's languages,

—water droplets in axisymmetry, [i],

phantom limbs, a skilled musiscian,

an Event-Related Potential.

ABBREVIATED SITUATEDNESS

1 first person

2 second person

3 third person

abl *ablative* (*removal, separation*)

abstr abstract noun

adabl adablative (*plus comparison*)

add additive particle

adess adessive (*nearness, like love*)

adjz adjectivizer

adterm adterminative (*4 years*)

adtrans adtranslative (*four feet further*)

adv adverbial

advb adverbial case

aff affirmative particle

agr agreement (*you, me, we*)

all allative (*get on top of me, love*)

anim animate

ante anteceding converb

aor aorist (*once upon a time…*)

approx approximative (*coming, approaching*)

apud APUD-locative

apudabl apudablative (*lative—far*)

apudess apudessive (*essive—near*)

apudlat apudlative

b B gender

ben benefactive

caus causative

cmp comparative

cond conditional

cont contact case (*even closer, touching*)

contr contrastive particle

cop copula

d D gender

dat dative

def definite

deict deictic particle (*indelible indices*)

dem demonstrative

dist *distal*

distr distributive

elat elative (*outness*)

emph emphatic particle

erg ergative

ess *essive* (*close, near, here*)

excl exclusive

f feminine

fut future

gen genitive

hab habitual

hort hortative (*dis-courag-ing*)

hpl human plural

iam iamitive (*I am essive*)

ill illative

imp imperative

imprf *imperfect*

in *IN-locative*

incl *inclusive*

indf *indefinite*

iness *inessive*

inf *infinit*-ive

ins instrumental

interabl interablative
intercont inter-contact case
interess interessive
interlat interlative
interterm interterminative
intertrans intertranslative
intr intransitive
intrans intranslative
ipfv imperfective
j J gender
lat lative
lv light verb
m masculine
med medial
mult multiplicative
neg negative
nmlz nominalizer
nom nominative
npst non-past
nw nonwitnessed
obl oblique
opt optative (*I wish; I hope*)
ord ordinal
pfv perfective
pl plural
pol polite
poss possessive
pot potential
priv privative (*a whisper*)
prog progressive
proh prohibitive
prox *proximal*
prs present
pst past
ptcl particle
ptcp participle
pv preverb
q question particle
quot quotative
recp reciprocal (*like love*)
redupl reduplication
refl reflexive (*like memory*)
rel relative (*a truth of various truths*)
rem remote past
rstrct restrictive (*a belief*)
sbjv subjunctive (*a notion*)
seq sequential
sg singular
simul simultaneous converb
subord subordinator
super SUPER-locative
superabl superablative
supercont supercontact case
superess superessive
superl *superlative*
superlat *super-lative case*
term terminative
tm thematic marker
tr transitive
trans translative
vn verbal noun
voc *e*-vocative

Relations externalized, embodied, reckoned.

[10] *What is glossed from that which we gloss over?*

"Tsova-Tush has no recognised official status in Georgia. According to Article 8 of the Georgian Constitution, the only official language in the country is the Georgian language, alongside the Abkhaz language in the occupied/secessionist territory of Abkhazia. Although minor policies towards the integration of some minorities have sporadically been implemented, such as the creation of minority language textbooks written in Georgian, and Georgian language textbooks written in minority languages, this has been done only for the minority languages with the largest numbers of speakers: Abkhaz, Armenian, Azeri, Megrelian, Ossetian and Svan. Smaller languages,

[10]As is the case for many communities in Kakheti.

such as Tsova-Tush, Kisti Chechen, Udi, Tat, Avar, Bezhta, Hunzib (all spoken in the eastern region of Kakheti) receive no governmental support whatsoever.11 One has to note that whenever non-governmental organisations run projects with the goal of strengthening minority rights, these projects select minorities based on ethnic self-identification, and therefore often do not include the Tsova-Tush, who have been self-identifying as ethnically Georgian for at least a century.[11]"

[11] (Wichers Schreur, 2024) pgs. 32-34

"There are no monolingual speakers of Batsbi; all speakers are also fluent in Georgian. As estimated above, less than half of people of Batsbi heritage speak the language, with a smaller portion of speakers in each new generation. Even among fluent Batsbi speakers, Georgian is nevertheless the main language of communication, and speakers often report feeling more competent in Georgian or finding Georgian easier to use. Many Batsbi speakers are competent in Russian as well."

"The first historical records that appartenly mention the Batsbi people date to the 6th or 7th centuries, or perhaps even earlier."[12]

Deltas:

Deltas are the transition stage between a river and a larger body of water—often a lake, sea or ocean. It reminds me of an old maxim—or at least one I remember my brother Sam telling me—that goes something like this: "we know more about the surface of the moon than we do the bottom of the ocean." There are two things that come to mind. The surface of the water is so vast, so endless, so conceivably inconceivable. But, at the same time, there's this sense that nothing can inhibit you besides what you can weather. That so long as you are alive, you can be anything and everything. We know this is never not true—humans are about as aware of our mutability as we are mutable. But what usually ends up happening is that we end up being nothing. We are so overwhelmed by this vastness that we don't know what to choose. We are marooned—adrift without a sight of shore. And rivers flow into us—not we them. So, when we confine ourselves to something whose boundaries we can conceivably trace, it's an upstream battle, and we're moving against the current. Moreover, there's a transition into these confines that we have to navigate. There are nearly countless tendrils that reach out to us, desperate to have us camp onto them, to rest our hides in their undercrofts. We find that we have to do this only for a moment, to navigate the labyrinth that is this transition into "certainty" where we try this place and then that.

The Mississippi Delta is approximately 3 million acres of land—which is about the size of the New York metropolitan area. The name "Delta" comes from the Greek letter of the same name. It was chosen because they often represent the same shape—that of a triangle. Truthfully, they share much more. In mathematics, the symbol represents change of any changeable quantity. Particularly, it is for the difference operator (–) which is the result when you make the computation. This was chosen due to it being the initial of the Greek word for difference /diaϕora/. It can also be used to signify the difference in symmetry between two sets, uncertainty in physical objects,

the derivative in calculus and science which is the tool that quantifies how sensitive a variable is to change. It can represent the interval of possible values for a given quantity, the rate of change for an option's price in financial markets, the determinacy of a variable in philosophical logic and the definition of a new variable or function in mathematics. The lowercase form of it also represents the change in the value of a variable in calculus. It's the symbol that represents the transitionary stage between states in a finite-state machine which is one that can have exactly one of a finite set of states at any given moment—this is to say that it represents the gap that exists between existent states[13]. It represents how much the nuclei of chemicals oscillate when made subject to a magnetic field. How much astronomical objects decline in a coordinate system, the depreciation of capital in a large economy, the amount of reactance based on voltage and current in an electrical system. If we were to apply this to the brain, it would represent the difference in electrical states of a neuron when it is excited—the negative peak at 400 milliseconds when a spoken word is fully integrated into memory. The letter, itself, was adopted into the Northern European alphabets via contact with the Roman Empire who, themselves, adopted the alphabet of which delta was a part. Originally, delta was called "dalet" in the Phoenician Alphabet before the name was metathesized into Greek when this alphabet was adopted. It has also been suggested that a sound change has since occurred in its transition to all these other languages such that the original sound of the letter was pronounced as a voiced interdental fricative similar to the sound at the beginning of the English words "*the*" and "*that*". However, since this sound didn't exist in Latin, it was replaced with "D" which was then rejected when the Romans made contact with some Northern and Western Germanic tribes—notably the Anglo-Saxons, the Welsh, the Danes, the Dutch, the Norse and the Irish. Instead, they used the letter "D" to represent the sound we know it

[13] So, a nonexistent existent state?

as today, and the Greek letter delta was reintroduced to represent the fricative. Afterwards, it was changed to become the letters ð and þ in the Old English alphabet—which is still used in Icelandic but has since dropped in English usage due to the influence of French on the English Language. It is an old letter and, thus, it has many wrinkles. Much like when I look at my mother's hands, I think of how many deltas and differences are shown in the tendrils that line her now aging skin. When she turns it over and I see the palm, it's a series of billions of transistors wrinkling to connect her to whatever it is she's touching—the cells, the tissue, like the wrinkles on the surface of a brain, they collect and gap the difference between two existent states, a forever-stage intermediate to the static stages...

There may be some universals in the cracks and wrinkles on your hand; but, the subtleties, the individually varied length in the middle knuckle of your pointer finger, the primary tool you may use to finger art into existence, the pinky—its length or lack thereof, its strength—why is there a fissure in your thumb print right above the inner swirl? Why does that vein wrap around the ligaments that bind your knuckles together that seems to crack when you twist your wrist in certain ways, when the islands on that delta between phalange and ulna constrict and pop a pocket of imprisoned fluid, a pocket dimension of your inner flesh, a lens providing clarity to a gradient blur.

Reconciliation of a shadowy memory, this time forgotten, or forgotten in time.

Occupation:

In August of 2024, at the start of my last year in my undergraduate, I took the first week off to travel to Zemo-Alvani, Georgia. The purpose of this trip was to participate in a short school on the process of language documentation. In this small community of so-called language scientists, Zemo-Alvani is reasonably well-known as being the home of the only population of people in the world to speak Tsova-Tush, a member of the Caucasian language group. There are about three broad domains of language groups that exist in the Caucasus region—namely, Indo-European, Altaic and Caucasian. In this small waistline between Europe and Asia, there are about 11.2 million speakers of dozens of languages. Regions like the Caucasus are especially ripe with linguistic diversity precisely because of the topography of winding mountains and deep valleys circumscribed by vast nothingness, sea.



Georgia sits between the Caucasus Mountains and the Black and Caspian seas—essentially making it a perfect case-study of the situation that often brings about language isolates. Isolates often give rise to pretty innovative grammatical features as a direct result of a lack of cross-linguistic

communication between language groups. What makes Georgia so perfect for this is that, over long periods of time, disparate peoples are interacting with each other so little due to the mountains, seas and whatever else the earth throws at them. Georgian, itself, has enough verbal clitics, forms and tenses to make one's head spin. Like most of the languages it's related to—really, all of them—it is an agglutinating language. As such, there's a basic template for verbs that dictates where certain grammatical elements get attached to which, eventually, create an entire relationship between all the elements of a common sentence. The preverbal element is a curious feature: it is

preverb	prefixal person marker	version marker	VERB ROOT	passive marker	{thematic suffix}	causative marker	imperfective marker	Mood/row marker	auxiliary verb	suffixal person marker	plural marker

postulated that the morphemes that sit in the preverbal place were originally post-positions for the nouns they modify. Because of this, they most often encode directionality, time duration or location. But, over time, certain arguments of the sentence are dropped for one reason or another. Then, the post-position is cliticized onto the verb and then this becomes a regular grammatical feature. Among other things, this is the morpheme *se* in Spanish, though it arose differently. It is no wonder, then, that almost all languages that have preverbal elements are in subject-object-verb order most of the time. Moreover, these often subject-object-verb languages prefer post-positions for their adpositional phrases, so these adpositions then get attached to another element of the sentence—rather than the noun of the object, for example, they will switch to the verb. Why? A lot of reasons, but I reckon that it might be because one argument is dropped in certain contexts. One of our first days there, one of our consultants got up to speak at a gathering the community held for us. In that room, there were a handful of people from France's CNRS as a push from the government to engage itself and its citizens in more community-based research. They had special offerings to Georgian students and brought scholars from Georgian universities in to collaborate and organize. The room itself was in a restaurant across the street from the empty school where

we conducted most of our classes and meetings. Outside the school was an intersection of a highway and some local roads cut with a statue of Stalin, who was born in this province, which was in the national news some years prior for being proposed to be taken down, hugging the backside of the school. Alongside the French researchers and some others were the rest of us—mostly students from across the Atlantic, but also a handful of European students, one prominent linguistic documentarian from the Netherlands and a couple Russian students. The rest, members of the community, people who, decades ago, never knowing it, would live to see the



rest of their language potentially die with them, a dozen of the last hundred speakers. It was said by a number of the people we worked with that Tsova-Tush "can express every aspect of the human soul and the universe"—not an uncommon sentiment, nor an irrational one. The basic nature of a language's existence is that it is tremendously useful for expressing things. It must be—that's how we are able to exist among, with and about each other. *How can I make you know what I know? How can I express to you the beauty I feel in my soul, the potency I see safeguarded in one's*

expression of guilt, of shame or vulnerability, the trembling of their fingers pressed to skin, the salvation I feel upon me when I meet with the eyes of the divine, the righteousness I feel when I defend someone I love, the shape of the air in the room when we shut off all the lights and read a section of Tender Buttons? By the end of the week, we had split into specialized groups for certain aspects of the language. There was a revitalization group, a sounds group and about four or five morpho-syntax groups. Mine investigated the use of the copula verb in instances of non-verbal predication. Roughly, there are a handful of ways these types of relationships can be expressed: no verb whatsoever, a single verb called the copula or multiple copulas with their own semantic grounding. English is usually an example of the second and sometimes an example of the first. For the third, one would only have to look at a handful of other languages to get a sense. Most notably, Spanish uses two different verbs, *ser* and *estar*. What tends to govern the use of these cross-linguistically is that certain types of being, properties, states of existence or whatever else prefer one type of conceptual grounding over another. What does this mean? It means that languages and language-users tend to understand that being *somewhere* is different from being *young*, or a *doctor*, or *dead*, or *alive*, or *someone's friend*, or *someone's lifelong love*, or being *green*, or *white*, or *black*. Or, that some of those are different from each other. Sometimes, languages will use an overt copula for the more permanent states and drop it for the less permanent ones—in English, for example, you can say "where you at?" and this is more acceptable than "you young" or "you stupid" to some speakers—namely, those who use the overt copula more often than those who don't. In any case, the question of concern is this: what *grounds* or *anchors* the object of experience to this conceptual basis or that and, moreover, how can we frame or encode this relationship in the language? Really, this is how human languages came to be at all—a reckoning of what questions we can ask and communicate about something and the reckoning of their answers. When we noun, we wonder

what kind or *type* it is—and, thus, we have a gender, a class. When we verb, we ask *who, when, where* and *how* about it—and, thus, we have verb classes, tense, aspect, mood, and even the various forms of being in relation to time in relation to the universe in relation to us and each other—the *objective*, the nauseatingly *subjective* and the oft-forgotten *intersubjective*. What is language but a tuning to the relationships humans reckon?

The question of how this kind of thing comes to be is what drives practically every theoretical linguist on the planet. Even looking at how a single language decides to communicate certain things and discriminate between them is enough to make your head spin and inspire faith in the divine. But, more directly, some of us more recently have asked "how does a speaker know when they are supposed to voice a sound, for example, without there being some internal system that directs them to do so?" Broadening it, how do we learn to do any of the things we do? How do any of us learn to use the water bottle we drink out of or to type on our computers or write with a pen? Generally, we copy the actions of the people we observe—we imitate. This presents a problem—namely that it seems unreasonable for someone to memorize every aspect of these vast languages and, as Chomsky noted, we seem to be quite creative with it! But consider how basic mechanisms form and work. The same way I don't consciously think about the process of bringing the cup to my mouth, opening my lips and taking a sip of it, so, then, do we not consciously think about the individual phones—it's muscle memory, it's a learned skill, a process. Merleau-Ponty would imagine a skilled musician—when you learn to play piano exceptionally well, you get to a point where making certain chords becomes automatic and then you can focus on other things like keeping your voice in tune if you're singing or thinking about time, tempo or rhythm. This, I reckon, is how we learn to speak. Then, if we think of language use as a behavior that evolves and, like many habitual actions, is recontextualized in new, creative ways, then it shouldn't be a huge

leap to see the evolution of a common plow and draw a similarity to the evolution of a common tongue. There's a dynamic that Tomasello et al. (1993) identifies in the cultural learning of chimpanzees and humans through the learned use of tools—the question of innovation or imitation. Essentially, why, if we learn through imitation, do we sometimes innovate? If cultural, linguistic or behavioral habits are an extension of our physical bodies, and encoded in there like pressing the correct keys of a piano, like the extension of expression the pianist has, then what happens when if you bind a couple of the pianists fingers together or chop them off entirely? They learn to use their hands differently. Indeed, they almost relearn how the play the piano entirely the same way a blind person may relearn to see. Really, this is the case with a ton of our cultural practices in all the broadest of senses—we use them so long as they are useful to us. What are we left with? Phantoms and phantom limbs.

The de facto voice of our consultants was a woman named Niko Kadagidze, perhaps the most prominent scholar on Tsova-Tush and progenitor of the first Tsova-Tush to Georgian and Russian dictionaries—resources we, ourselves, used in our sessions and preparations, resources I read on the bus to Chicago and flight to Frankfurt. She taught at the University of Tbilisi for several decades in the Department of Languages and Linguistics. She has authored dozens of manuscripts regarding the language, spoken for possibly thousands of hours on the subject and yet, to this day, it is one of the languages we are told is unknown, under-documented and on the brink of death—not without reason. When she stood up, looking upon a room so full of people that half of them didn't have chairs to sit in, she expressed her pride in a smoker's baritone that her life's work had come to a satisfying close. The part that struck me most about the whole 10-minute or so speech was when she said something along the lines of "ადამიანს აქვს ორი სახლი: მისი ტერიტორია, რომელიც არის სივრცე მსოფლიოში, რომელსაც ის უკავია და ენა„ which

roughly translates to “there are two homes a person has: their territory, which is the space in the universe they occupy, and their language.” The sound of her voice, cleared in the room, silent, a few phones recording, the dynamics of occupation at hand.

Jesse Wichers Schruer Class Handout and Dissertation, *Intense language contact in Eastern Georgia: The case of Tsova-Tush.* 08.26.24. Zemo Alvani, Georgia.

Ex.1.3 gender / ex. 2.1 spatial case
Compiled by Isabelle Roy, ***rend***er***ed*** and contacted by Jacob Boudreau.

predication

(2)	*donen jol čamli^{n} ja*	‘To a horse, hay is delicious.’
(5)	*o vʃevuin va*	‘He is a killer.’
(8)	*o bacba^{n} joɦ ja*	‘She is a Tsova-Tush girl.’
(16)	*lebiv čamli^{n} ba.*	‘Beans are tasty.’
(28)	*k’naten načx jagi^{n}. o jaqqo^{n} jar.*	‘The boy saw a cheese. It was big.’
(30)	*delar ǧaze^{n} da*	‘Laughing is good.’
(22)	*pst’i memcxoriǫo dar*	‘The women were with the shepherds.’

locatives

(18)	*k’nati ba xen mak*	‘The boys are in the tree.’
(19)	*daqqo^{n} dui xen k’ik’el dar*	‘The big horses were under the tree.’

(11)	*nan-dad da sogo*	*so*	‘My parents are with me.’	
(12)	*ese jasŏ bare*	*bar*	‘I am here in the valley.’	
(23)	*dalgore^{n} co va*	*dal*	‘He is not from God.’	> negation
(36)	*indurtele^{n} pešk’ar da*	*indurt*	‘He was a boy from Indurta.’	
(42)	*txe^{n} pɦere^{n} co vaɦŏ*	*pɦe*	‘You are not from our village.’	

existential

(6)	*cɦa vaqqo^{n} st’ak’ var*	‘There was one big man.’
(14)	*badre^{n} bexk’ bar*	‘It was the child’s fault.’

nominal modification

(9)	*jelin joɦ*	‘A laughing girl.’

The North Wind and the Sun in Tsova-Tush
By D.A. Holisky

[14'] matx upr zoroUxU b-ar.
sun more brave-COMP be-IMPF
'the sun was braver.'

[14'] Here both the inflected and periphrastic comparatives are used together. The verb 'be' shows class agreement with the subject, 'sun'.

[13''] vux d-o-qe-r maxav.
what-NOM do-else-IMPF wind-ERG
'What else could the wind do?'

[14''] ħal b-3oq-b-aliⁿ matx zorovx b-ainO.
PBV admit-AOR sun brave-COMP be-QUOT
'He admitted that the sun was the braver.'

[14''] In this alternative a different form of the comparative adjective was given. The verb 'be' shows class agreement with 'sun' and the final phrase is given as indirect speech, marked by the quotative suffix -aino.

He admitted that he was.

The place known today as The Republic of Georgia has been settled by human beings for about as long as there have been human beings. On my first day there, I visited the National Museum in Tbilisi which displayed this skull of a Homo Georgicus, a species of humans who gave rise to some of the first stone tools almost two million years ago. It was the site of an archeological dig that unearthed this specimen. This was far from the only discovery though, since it was buried in the ancient home of what can only be described as a village street occupied by stone houses. These remains are still considered the earliest known presence of a Hominin species outside of Africa. There is evidence of early nation-states appearing in the Caucasus from the time before Abrahamic religions existed. Here, nations are presumed to have been farming, trading and occasionally warring with each other—nothing one would not expect from a nation. Though, they remained relatively primitive for how long they had to build. Around this time, the various peoples living in southern Georgia became the first ones to turn specific grapevines into alcohol, producing

the world's first wines. Only after the Greeks expanded past Anatolia did they discover and eventually produce their own wine where we derive the common image of hedonism. Around this time, a small portion of the Nakh people, mostly shepherds and peregrine farmers, emigrated from



the north faces of the Northern Caucasus to the south. Then, some five or six centuries later, Christianity was introduced to the people of the Caucasus, and there came about an architectural revolution. The Alaverdi Monastery, located a few kilometers east of the city of Akhmeti, was built at the start of the Golden Age of Georgia by the ruler Kvirike III the Great of Kakheti. To this day, it is still undergoing regular renovations and upkeep. Until the erection of The Holy Trinity Cathedral of Tbilisi, Alaverdi was the highest-standing structure in Georgia. Today, the wine cellar is over 11 centuries old and one of the world's oldest-living olive trees stands in the monastery yard. By the eleventh century, all of Georgia was united under one kingdom following Christianity. When you walk through the Old Town section of Tbilisi that my cab driver from the airport took me through, you can still place your eyes on the towers that the Bagrat dynasty built brick by brick almost a thousand years ago, just a few blocks from where a statue of Ronald Reagan and a mural of George W. Bush now exist. At this time, the oldest structures of the Tush people that are still standing today were being built. As nomadic people, the Tush would abandon their villages and seek shelter in these scattered towers across the mountainsides at signs of trouble. In the latter half of the thirteenth century, the Mongol Empire invaded and fragmented into a number of smaller kingdoms that had arisen after the unifying force of Christianity. Over the next 500 years, the once great kingdom of Georgia was passed between occupiers of its territory, one empire after another, and every Georgian ruler thenceforward had to face the choice of paying tribute to their invaders or suffering increasingly horrific losses of life. There were moments of independence, but they were always short-lived. One last hope, uncovered by the eastern rulers, remained: protection from the Kievan Rus to the North. The north wind and the sun fell and the moon fell on the 18th century, and the Georgian rulers signed a treaty with Russia in 1783, establishing a protectorate. Shortly thereafter, these eastern provinces were annexed. By the end of the century, the entire kingdom

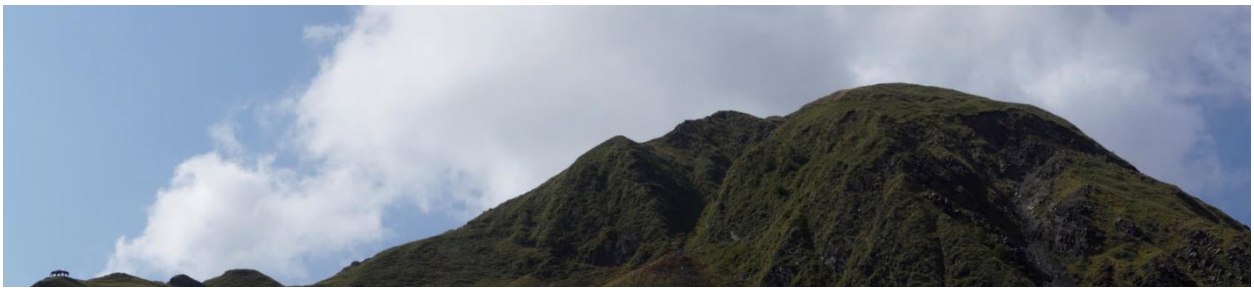


was under Russian occupation. The Kingdom of Georgia never recovered. In the early 20th century, after some years of stability with growing nationalism from Georgians, they declared their independence from Russian occupation. The Republic of Georgia was born. On its third birthday, the Soviet red army invaded. Decades later, Soviet infrastructure was established and up



to ninety-five percent of the population was literate. Today, most Georgians who lived through the Soviet era speak at least two languages and can read three different scripts: Cyrillic, Georgian and Latin. A number have a third language—that of their homes, the ones their parents spoke, Tsova-Tush, Abkhaz, Lezgian, Georgian, some Armenian, or a more socio-politically useful one, like English—occupied territories, unoccupied languages. In 1991, they declared their independence a second time. For the next ten years, the country was fraught with a war of secession, political corruption and economic instability. In 2008, Russia annexed the northern part of the Caucasus mountains, about a third of Georgia‘s total landmass at the time, further working to reassimilate them into a new Russian federation. Today, there is a constant standoff between Georgian and Russian troops, political leaders in Georgia are entertaining rejoining Russia despite “fuck Putin” being spraypainted on nearly every building in downtown Tbilisi, despite every public space in a small town just a few miles away from Stalin’s birthplace flying European Union flags. On our

final day there, we drove up into the mountains where they cooked a meal for us. Some of us hiked to a reservoir further up from our stop. Ahead, just beyond the edge of sight, we spot a glimpse of white and debate whether it's a packet of snow. I argue that it's impossible given the fact that it's



the end of summer and it's been far too warm for so much to accumulate. A couple others note that we are, indeed, high enough in elevation for it to be feasible. Elevation is a tricky thing—a foot or two in height, a slope uncertain, thinning air, sea level—the metrics are so entangled, so confused, so interactive and contradictory to be certain how a set of homes can be affected, but once you're so high up, you can see the valleys spread below, like festering mold on bread, or the significant presence of ejective consonants. Overhead, a pair of horses were spotted just south of the nearest peak. Being the only one who had a quality camera on hand, I took this picture. Seconds later, a breeze blew through and we decided to head back. The people here have left their impressions on me. I know this—I know this because of how natural this group, together, feels, how intimately I have come to feel this confused amalgam of people, all interacting, all debating, contradicting, reinforcing and devaluing each other in this entangled, confused mess—how did it come to be us? How did it come to be these people and only these people? Like the eighty or so kids I graduated high school with, there's an uncanny familiarity with which I associate their faces, the sounds of their voices, the mannerisms that are as much a part of them as their hair or skin, like the first time hearing a new song, like another day lived like it's your first day alive, like every single cell of your body at the end of time—the nucleus of a birthing universe with new, uncertain languages to

describe every aspect of being human, being a subject of and subject to history, memory—embodied, incarnate and never, ever detached. People tend to occupy, impress, such is peopling. Walking down one of the many faces of the Tusheti valleys, I stopped, looked back, and took a photo I was more satisfied with. Better to have more witnesses to an annihilated memory, occupied by new people in every new moment, dissolving—better to have one last glimpse of faces being lost forever. Every day, Russian troops advance and move the borderline just a little bit further into Georgia. Every day, a handful of Georgians fall asleep in Georgia and wake up in Russia.



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